



UNITED NATIONS FASHION COMMITTEE (UN FASHION)

Background Paper

Topic:

The Impact of Fast Fashion on Climate Change

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I. Introduction to the United Nations and Climate Governance

The United Nations (UN) was established in 1945 to promote international peace, cooperation, and sustainable development. Over time, climate change has become one of the most pressing global challenges addressed within the UN system.

Through agreements such as the Paris Agreement, Member States committed to limiting global temperature rise to well below 2°C, ideally 1.5°C above pre-industrial levels.

Climate governance within the UN is supported by institutions such as the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change (UNFCCC), which facilitates negotiations and climate policy frameworks.

Within this context, industries with high environmental impact—including the global fashion sector—have come under increasing scrutiny.

II. Introduction to the Topic

Fast fashion refers to the rapid production of inexpensive clothing designed to follow quickly changing trends. The business model prioritizes speed, low costs, and high consumption.

Major fast fashion companies such as:

- Zara

- H&M
- Shein

have transformed global consumption patterns by producing large quantities of low-cost garments.

However, the fashion industry is responsible for approximately 8–10% of global carbon emissions, making it one of the most polluting industries worldwide. Fast fashion contributes significantly to:

- Greenhouse gas emissions
- Water overconsumption
- Textile waste
- Microplastic pollution
- Exploitative labor practices

The environmental impact of fast fashion directly intersects with global climate goals.

III. Historical Background

The rise of fast fashion began in the 1990s and early 2000s, facilitated by globalization, outsourcing, and technological advancements in supply chain management.

Production shifted largely to developing countries where labor costs were lower. While this created economic opportunities, it also increased environmental degradation and carbon-intensive manufacturing processes.

The 2013 Rana Plaza collapse exposed severe labor and safety violations in the garment industry, highlighting ethical concerns tied to fast fashion.

Over time, environmental awareness grew as reports revealed:

- Massive textile waste in landfills
- High water use in cotton production
- Fossil fuel dependency in synthetic fabrics such as polyester

The fashion industry's global supply chains make it a transnational environmental issue requiring international coordination.

IV. Legal and Environmental Framework

Several international frameworks are relevant:

1. The Paris Agreement

Encourages all sectors to reduce emissions in alignment with national climate commitments.

2. Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs)

Particularly:

- SDG 12: Responsible Consumption and Production
- SDG 13: Climate Action

3. Corporate Environmental Responsibility

Increasing emphasis on ESG (Environmental, Social, Governance) standards.

Despite these frameworks, there are currently limited binding international regulations specifically targeting fast fashion emissions and waste.

V. Current Situation (2026 Context)

As of 2026:

- Ultra-fast fashion models have accelerated online consumption.
- Clothing production continues to increase globally.
- Textile waste remains a major issue, particularly in developing nations receiving discarded garments.
- Consumers are increasingly demanding transparency and sustainability.

Some governments are considering:

- Carbon taxes on textile production
- Extended producer responsibility laws
- Bans on destruction of unsold inventory
- Circular economy policies

The debate centers around balancing:

- Economic growth and affordability
- Environmental sustainability
- Innovation in sustainable textiles
- Fair labor practices

VI. Key Questions for Debate

Delegates should consider:

1. Should fast fashion be regulated at the international level?
2. How can emissions from textile production be reduced?
3. Should companies be held legally accountable for textile waste?
4. How can sustainable alternatives be incentivized?
5. What role should consumer awareness play?

VII. Conclusion

The impact of fast fashion on climate change represents a critical intersection between consumer behavior, corporate responsibility, and global environmental governance.

Addressing this issue requires:

- International cooperation
- Private sector accountability
- Sustainable innovation
- Policy reform

The UN Fashion Committee must work toward solutions that reduce environmental harm while promoting equitable economic development and responsible consumption.

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